AGE 310: Instrumentation and Measurements

Dr. Kadeghe Fue, Department of Agricultural Engineering, SUA

Morogoro, Tanzania

Abstract

Lecture 2 focuses on the theoretical and practical framework that ensures uniformity and comparability in measurements globally. We explore the SI system, the hierarchy of standards critical for traceability, and fundamentally distinguish between continuous (analog) and discrete (digital) signals. Emphasis is placed on the $4 - 20$ mA industrial current loop and the electronic challenges of noise and signal fidelity.

Lecture 2: Measurement Standards and Signals

2.1 The System of International Units (SI) and Standards

2.1.1 The SI System

The International System of Units (SI) is the modern metric system based on seven base units. In modern metrology, these units are no longer defined by physical artifacts (like the kilogram prototype) but are linked to fundamental constants of nature.

- **Length:** Meter (m)
- **Mass:** Kilogram (kg)
- **Time:** Second (s)
- **Electric Current:** Ampere (A)
- **Temperature:** Kelvin (K)
- **Amount of Substance:** Mole (mol)
- **Luminous Intensity:** Candela (cd)

For Agricultural Engineering, units like Pascals (Pa, pressure) and Joules (J, energy) are derived from these base units.

2.1.2 Hierarchy of Standards

The integrity of the SI system is maintained through a hierarchical structure of measurement standards.

1. **International Standards:** Highest accuracy, maintained by the BIPM (Bureau International des Poids et Mesures) in France. Used only for verification of National Standards.
2. **Primary Standards (National):** Maintained by National Metrology Institutes, such as the TBS (Tanzania Bureau of Standards). These are rarely used, serving as the highest legal representation of the SI unit within the country.
3. **Secondary Standards (Reference):** Used by regional calibration centers (e.g., in Morogoro, Dar es Salaam) and advanced university laboratories (like SUA) for routine checking of working standards.
4. **Working Standards:** Used daily in laboratories, workshops, and for field calibration. Their accuracy is frequently verified against the secondary standards.

2.2 Traceability and Calibration Management

Traceability: The property of a measurement result whereby it can be related to a reference (national or international standard) through an unbroken chain of comparisons, all having stated uncertainties.

For example, the measurement from a GPS unit (Working Standard) used for farm mapping must be traceable back to the SI meter definition through the TBS and ultimately to the BIPM.

Calibration Interval: Instruments degrade over time due to wear, temperature, and drift. Therefore, calibration must be performed periodically (e.g., every 6 or 12 months) to maintain accuracy and traceability. Failing to calibrate means your data is *unreliable* and *untraceable* a serious professional error.

Calculation Example 1: Calibration Uncertainty

An AGE student uses a working standard thermometer to calibrate a farm thermometer. The working standard has an uncertainty of $\pm 0.1^{\circ}$C, and the calibration process itself introduces an uncertainty of $\pm 0.05^{\circ}$C.

The uncertainty of the calibrated thermometer (U_{cal}) is typically calculated as the root-sum-square of the contributing uncertainties:

$$U_{\text{cal}} = \sqrt{(U_{\text{standard}})^2 + (U_{\text{process}})^2}$$

Solution:

$$U_{\text{cal}} = \sqrt{(0.1^{\circ}\text{C})^2 + (0.05^{\circ}\text{C})^2}$$

$$U_{\text{cal}} = \sqrt{0.01 + 0.0025} = \sqrt{0.0125} \approx \pm 0.112^{\circ}\text{C}$$

The uncertainty of the measurement cannot be less than the uncertainty of the standard used.

2.3 Analog Signals

2.3.1 Definition and Characteristics

An **Analog Signal** is a continuous function of time. The signal's amplitude can take on any value within a given range at any instant.

- **Nature:** Most natural physical phenomena are analog (temperature, light intensity, pressure, fluid flow).
- **Amplitude:** Infinite possible values (e.g., a voltage can be 2.000 V, 2.001 V, 2.0001 V, etc.).
- **Examples:** Voltage from a thermocouple, current from a photovoltaic cell, displacement of a pointer.

[Image of Continuous sine wave analog signal on a graph illustrating infinite amplitude values]

2.3.2 Advantages and Disadvantages

Advantages:

- **High Density:** Captures the full detail of the physical phenomenon (infinite resolution).
- **Simple Processing:** Basic signal conditioning like amplification and filtering can be done easily with Op-Amps.

Disadvantages:

- **Noise Susceptibility:** Electrical noise (EMI) directly alters the amplitude, corrupting the data permanently.
- **Degradation:** Signal quality degrades over long transmission distances (attenuation and resistance).

2.4 Digital Signals

2.4.1 Definition and Characteristics

A **Digital Signal** is discrete in both time and amplitude. It represents data as a sequence of discrete numerical values, typically using binary code (0 or 1).

- **Amplitude:** Limited to a finite set of values (e.g., 0 V and 5 V for CMOS logic).
- **Process:** Requires Analog-to-Digital Conversion (ADC) to discretize the signal.
- **Examples:** Communication protocols (I2C, SPI), pulse counts, or a switch being ON/OFF.

2.4.2 The ADC Process (Sampling and Quantization)

The conversion of an analog signal (V_a) to a digital signal (D) involves two steps:

1. **Sampling:** Taking measurements (snapshots) of the analog signal at discrete, regular time intervals. The *Sampling Frequency* (f_s) must adhere to the Nyquist theorem to avoid aliasing.
2. **Quantization:** Assigning a discrete numerical value to each sampled snapshot. The number of steps is determined by the ADC's resolution (bit depth).

Calculation Example 2: ADC Resolution A standard Arduino microcontroller uses a 10-bit ADC over a voltage range of 0 V to 5 V.

- **Number of Quantization Levels (N):**

$$N = 2^{10} = 1024 \text{ steps}$$

- **Resolution (ΔV):** The smallest voltage change the ADC can distinguish.

$$\Delta V = \frac{\text{Voltage Range}}{N} = \frac{5 \text{ V}}{1024} \approx 0.00488 \text{ V/step} \approx 4.88 \text{ mV/step}$$

If a sensor output changes by 2 mV, the 10-bit ADC will not register the change, indicating the resolution is 4.88 mV.

2.5 Signal Transmission and Industrial Loops

2.5.1 Voltage vs. Current Transmission

For communication, the signal must be reliably moved from the sensor to the controller.

- **Voltage Signals ($0-10$ V):** Suitable for short distances. Highly susceptible to signal degradation over long cables due to wire resistance causing voltage drop ($\Delta V = I \cdot R$) and capacitive coupling to external noise.
- **Current Signals ($4-20$ mA):** The preferred industrial standard. Kirchhoff's Current Law ensures current is constant at all points in a series loop, minimizing the effect of wire resistance and noise over long distances (hundreds of meters).

2.5.2 The $4-20$ mA Current Loop

This is the standard analog signal used in almost all industrial and agricultural process control (PLC systems).

Live Zero: The loop uses 4 mA to represent the minimum value (0%) of the measured range, and 20 mA for the maximum value (100%).

Advantages of the Live Zero (4 mA):

1. **Fault Detection:** If the current drops to 0 mA, the system immediately knows the wire has broken or the transmitter has lost power (a fault condition), distinguishing it from a true zero reading (4 mA).
2. **Powering the Sensor:** The 4 mA "live zero" current can be used to power low-consumption sensors in a 2-wire setup.

Calculation Example 3: $4-20$ ***mA Scaling*** A hydrostatic level sensor in a large water tank in Kilombero measures water depth from 0 m to 10 m. This range is scaled to a $4-20$ mA output.

1. Calculate the current output when the water depth is 6 m.
2. Determine the depth if the measured current is 15 mA.

Solution:

1. **Range of Current (I_{range}):** 20 mA $-$ 4 mA $=$ 16 mA. **Range of Depth (D_{range}):** 10 m $-$ 0 m $=$ 10 m.

   A. Current at 6 m depth: Fraction of range: 6 m$/10$ m $=$ 0.6 Current above zero: 0.6×16 mA $=$ 9.6 mA Output Current (I_{out}): 4 mA $+$ 9.6 mA $=$ 13.6 mA

2. **B. Depth at 15 mA current:** Current above zero: 15 mA $-$ 4 mA $=$ 11 mA Fraction of range: 11 mA$/16$ mA $=$ 0.6875 Depth (D): 0.6875×10 m $=$ 6.875 m

2.6 Noise and Impedance Matching

2.6.1 Sources and Types of Noise

Noise is any unwanted electrical signal that interferes with the primary measurement signal.

- **Thermal Noise (Johnson-Nyquist):** Caused by the random motion of electrons in a resistor (proportional to temperature).
- **Electromagnetic Interference (EMI):** External noise induced by nearby power lines, radio waves, or switching equipment (e.g., a tractor ignition system).
- **Ground Loops:** Unwanted currents flowing through the ground connection when components are connected to different ground potentials.

2.6.2 Signal-to-Noise Ratio (SNR)

The SNR is a crucial figure of merit that quantifies the quality of a signal.

$$\text{SNR} = \frac{P_{\text{signal}}}{P_{\text{noise}}}$$

Where P is the power. SNR is usually expressed in decibels (dB):

$$\text{SNR}_{\text{dB}} = 10 \log_{10} \left(\frac{P_{\text{signal}}}{P_{\text{noise}}} \right)$$

A higher SNR means a cleaner signal and a better measurement.

Calculation Example 4: SNR The output signal from a soil moisture sensor has a power of 10 mW. The measured noise power is 25 µW. Calculate the SNR in dB.

Solution: First, ensure units are consistent (1 mW $= 1000$ µW).

$$\text{SNR} = \frac{10,000 \text{ µW}}{25 \text{ µW}} = 400$$

$$\text{SNR}_{\text{dB}} = 10 \log_{10}(400) \approx 26.02 \text{ dB}$$

An SNR of 26 dB is generally acceptable in industrial environments.

2.6.3 Impedance Matching

To maximize power transfer and minimize reflections (signal ghosting) between components, the output impedance of the source must match the input impedance of the load. In sensor interfaces, we often use amplifiers with high input impedance to ensure they draw minimal current, thereby avoiding the loading effect.

2.7 Summary of Key Terms (Swahili/Context)

- **Standard:** Kiwango (The ultimate reference value).
- **Traceability:** Mnyororo wa uthibitisho (The unbroken chain of calibration).
- **TBS:** Shirika la Viwango Tanzania (Tanzania Bureau of Standards).
- **Analog Signal:** Ishara endelevu (Continuous, time-varying signal).
- **Digital Signal:** Ishara ya namba/diskreti (Discrete, numerical signal).
- **Baud Rate:** Kasi ya mawasiliano (The speed at which data is transmitted serially).
- **Live Zero:** 4 mA inayotumika (The minimum current used to detect faults).
- **Noise Immunity:** Kinga dhidi ya kelele (Resistance to electrical interference).

Lecture 2: Review Questions

SECTION A: Basic Concepts (5 Questions)

1. Explain the concept of *Traceability* in measurement. Why must every instrument used in the SUA farm be traceable?
2. State two distinct advantages of using a 4-20 mA current loop for transmitting data from a sensor placed 300 m away in a large wheat field, compared to using a $0 - 5$ V voltage signal.
3. Differentiate between the two methods of discretization involved in Analog-to-Digital Conversion (ADC).
4. Define the term *Baud Rate* in serial communication and explain why both the transmitter and receiver must agree on this rate for successful communication.
5. Briefly explain why the modern definition of the kilogram is now based on the Planck constant, rather than a physical cylinder in France.

SECTION B: Advanced Analysis and Calculations (10 Questions)

6. **ADC Resolution and Error:** A 12-bit ADC is used with a sensor having an output range of 0 V to 10 V.
   - Calculate the voltage resolution in mV/step.
   - If the sensor output is 3.14 V, what is the nearest integer digital value produced by the ADC?
7. **Current Loop Scaling (Advanced):** A temperature transmitter measures temperatures from $0°$C to $100°$C.
   - Determine the temperature at which the output current is 18 mA.
   - What is the current output when the temperature is $-5°$C (assuming the sensor operates linearly below the minimum range)?
8. **SNR Calculation:** A communication system for a remote weather station has a signal power of 1 W. Due to faulty shielding, the noise power is 50 µW. Calculate the SNR in dB. Is this SNR sufficient for reliable 9600 baud data transmission? Justify your answer.
9. **Nyquist Theorem:** A vibration sensor installed on a tractor engine measures a rotational speed (frequency) of 60 Hz. According to the Nyquist theorem, what is the minimum required sampling frequency (f_s) to avoid signal aliasing? If the system samples at 100 Hz, what error are you likely to introduce?
10. **Standards Hierarchy (Tanzania Context):** Identify the appropriate class of standard (International, Primary, Secondary, Working) for the following scenarios:
    - A mass balance used to weigh students' laboratory reports in the AGE department.
    - The official weight standard maintained by TBS.
    - The artifact that defined the SI unit of time before 2019.

11. **Live Zero Functionality:** Explain in detail the critical importance of the 4 mA "live zero" in industrial process control. What specific failure mode does it allow the controller to instantly distinguish from a legitimate measurement?

12. **Impedance and Loading Effect:** Explain the principle of *Impedance Matching*. How does measuring a voltage with a Voltmeter that has a low input impedance (relative to the source) introduce a Systematic Error?

13. **Digital vs. Analog Decision:** An engineer needs to choose between using an analog voltage signal ($0-5$ V) or an I2C digital signal to transfer data from a new GPS module to a central controller. The distance is 1.5 m. Which signal type is better suited for this short-distance, high-integrity data transfer, and why?

14. **Error in Calibration Chain:** A SUA calibration technician uses a Secondary Standard thermometer with an uncertainty of $\pm 0.05^{\circ}$C. The calibration process itself adds $\pm 0.02^{\circ}$C uncertainty. Calculate the total uncertainty of the student's Working Standard thermometer after calibration.

15. **Noise Mitigation Techniques:** Identify and briefly describe two common hardware techniques (cabling or filtering) used to mitigate EMI or high-frequency noise from analog signals in long-distance agricultural applications.